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Dhikr rituals and culture change

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A Dhikr Ritual in the Resettled Village of Kanuba • Discussion

After about two hours of “dhikring” in this way, people began to leave the courtyard to return to their own sections of the village. Part of the group was not ready to go home, however, and they gathered outside in the street to continue to dance. One man held the lantern high as several boys took the roles of female dancers, again imitating the steps used in wedding dances. They became more vigorous than ever and began to clap and to beat the drums again, but after about half an hour their enthusiasm waned, and people dispersed to their houses.

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Discussion

The *dhikr* as performed in the resettled village of Kanuba in 1963 clearly illustrates many features differing from those of the traditional form described earlier. The spirit of religious dedication noted in Diwan was absent, as were the Ṣūfistic ideals of purity of soul, meditation, and union with the divine. The traditional pattern of the *dhikr* was not followed, nor even known. For example, there were no *naqīb*, *moqrī*, or *munshids*. The *istighār* was not recited and the excerpts from the Qur'ān repeated at various points were not taken seriously. Many of those present did not even listen to them and some were laughing in other parts of the courtyard. The *estiftāh al-dhikr* was not changed, but the recitation of a *qaṣīda* was fragmentary, with verses taken from several different books. These were remnants of the traditional form, and the overall performance was characterized by spontaneity, dis-

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organization, and secularism at variance with the formal pattern and sacred quality of the traditional *dhikr*.

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Rather than beginning quietly and then gradually and systematically building to a climax of rhythmic action, the men began moving excitedly and somewhat randomly at the outset, laughing and joking. The whole atmosphere was recreational. Sacred words were chanted, but the spirit of 55 religious dedication, which had so impressed us in Diwan, was absent. Another difference was the individuality of participation, such as was shown, for example, when one of the young leaders initiated a step of his own, a kind of irregular jumping different from what most of the others were doing. During the most excited part of the *dhikr* men were bending low and boisterously leaping high in the air with loud shouts at any time they felt moved to do so.

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